does not get any disability pension, nor is he entitled to such extended medical care (see *A World of Disparities*).

Many officers believe that issues impacting morale will inevitably crop up as a rising number of Agniveers take the field alongside regular soldiers due to different terms and service conditions. Agniveers, due to their short service period, cannot be given any technical training or be sent on military courses. Crucially, they are allowed only 30 days annual leave, as against 90 days for others—a matter that may breed disaffection.

The first batch of Agniveers has been posted in the field units since September 2023 after completing their six months training. For the first time for persons below officer rank, every aspiring Agniveer underwent a psychometric test as part of the selection process. This is to evaluate each applicant's mental aptitude and personality traits to assess if he is mentally fit for a demanding job. Initial feedback on the Agniveers from the unit commanders is mixed, but barring a few instances of indiscipline, their behaviour has been "encouraging and positive" and they have exhibited good combat skills. A unit commander posted in the Kashmir Valley tells INDIA TODAY that Agniveers are technology savvy and very focused. "It could be because they have to prove themselves in their four years of service, till they are chosen to be absorbed as regular soldiers," he says.

## The Way Forward

Maj. Gen. Ashok Kumar (retd), currently director at the Centre for Joint Warfare Studies, supports the scheme, but says it does require course correction. Significantly, he proposes increasing the percentage of retention from 25 per cent to at least 50 per cent. He also feels that the scheme would have profited if it had been vetted through parliamentary debates.

Lt Gen. Vinod Bhatia (retd), former Director General of Military Operations, believes that the Agnipath scheme in its present form does not further the operational effectiveness of the armed forces. He says an impact analysis of the Agniveers, assessing their operational, training, administrative, discipline and morale parameters is imperative. He also adds that there is a need to enhance the service period to a minimum of seven to eight years and the percentage of retention to 50, with those being trained in technical matters being recruited for a full length of service. He also recommends equality of pay/ allowances and death/ disability benefits for Agniveers.



**"If the Constitution has been amended over 100 times, then any policy can be modified. Every scheme requires a modification based on the feedback on the ground"**

**GEN. M.M. NARAVANE (RETD)**
**Former Chief of Army Staff**

Maj. Gen. Yash More (retd), a trenchant critic of Agnipath, claims that the scheme was introduced without much consultation with army headquarters. "In one stroke, the time-tested process of recruitment, refined over decades, was dismantled," he says, while adding that the scheme not only destroyed the aspirations of millions of youths but also negatively impacted the army units' efficiency. Maj. Gen. More juxtaposes the Agniveers' six-month training with the fact that it takes around seven-eight years to train a soldier capable of handling tanks, combat vehicles and air defence/ artillery weapon systems. The scheme ignores the technical training so crucial for cutting-edge combat, he laments. "The competition among Agniveers to become permanent after four years is likely to create unhealthy competition harmful to an organisation that relies on team spirit as the basis of fighting strength," Maj. Gen. More says.

Pranay Kotasthane, deputy director at the Takshashila Institution, feels the government can consider a revised Agnipath that addresses the major concerns of Agniveers who retire after serving their four-year terms. One way would be to retain them in the national security ecosystem—the Central/ State Armed Police Forces (CAPF/ SAPF)—which face a shortage of trained personnel. Like Lt. Gen. Bhatia, he, too, thinks Agnipath service should be extended to seven-eight years. "This new model will likely reduce the apprehensions that applicants have with Agnipath 1.0. As the longer service term of seven-eight years reduces turnover, it is likely to find more support within the armed forces. Finally, it can also improve the recruiting paramilitary organisations' combat capabilities," Kotasthane says.

The Modi 3.0 regime has shown willingness to refine Agnipath and make it more effective and appealing. If it addresses the concerns raised by the stakeholders and implements the recommended improvements, the government would go far in balancing the modernisation goals of the armed forces with the welfare and career prospects of its young Agniveers. ■